

Q What role do you play in Fedora and Red Hat?

I head a group called the Community Architecture and Leadership team and am based in Singapore. What we do is to effectively work with the global open source communities outside Red Hat, and Fedora is one of those communities. We are responsible for bridging 'internal Red Hat' with the external community. We do not dictate anything from a community point of view. We just make sure that the corporate world does the right thing as far as the community is concerned. We keep looking out for opportunities for Red Hat in the open source community that we can participate in. Whenever an open source community, including Fedora, requires our support or needs to engage with Red Hat, we facilitate that as well.

Q What was your group's contribution in Fedora 20, and what are the new offerings in this open source distro?

Fedora is run as a community project. The Fedora Project Leader is, essentially, the go-to person for anything to do with the distro. She is a full time employee of Red Hat, but her focus is more on Fedora related issues, so she is called the Fedora Project Leader. She takes care of the new ideas, new directions, handles issues, if any, et al. That is her role, and it is largely driven by what the community needs and not what Red Hat requires as a business. So Fedora is very community focused and community driven. Red Hat's investment is to have individuals being paid a salary to work on Fedora projects. Red Hat also provides the infrastructure, servers, bandwidth, hosting and support for the Fedora project.

Fedora 20 is an interesting offering. Fedora is an evolving project, so there are many new components that have become a lot more mature in this release. An example is SystemD, which is a way to start and stop services and processes within an operating system. This is evolutionary if you look at how this was done earlier in the UNIX world. We have actually moved away from that model of starting and stopping services, to what we are calling the SystemD approach. It has reached a level that is a lot more mature today. What this basically means to end users is that their systems will be starting up and shutting down much quicker than earlier. And when users want to use email services, control a firewall, or run other such services that involve managing and maintaining a system, SystemD gives a lot more functionality for it to be done in a more granular fashion compared to what was available before. The previous methods were based on technologies and ideas that came from the 1980s and 1990s in the UNIX space.

While in many ways it is evolutionary, yet at the same time, it is revolutionary in the way systems are being managed moving forward in the Fedora space. What happens as a result of this is that these technologies find their way into the enterprise side of the house, which

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is Red Hat Enterprise Linux. So lessons learnt in how we go about using SystemD, the best practices, what we need to be aware of because of the changing way in how you manage our systems, the disadvantages and how we address them, et al, all find space in RHEL when it adopts SystemD as a default, across the board. You will see these features coming out in RHEL 7.

In addition, we had improvements and updates to the graphical interface GNOME 3.10. We also have KDE updates to it. So there are more incremental changes that have been made to the latest Fedora.

Q Fedora earlier occupied the top spot with respect to usage. That position has now been taken over by Ubuntu. How do you view this situation?

As far as Red Hat and the open source community is concerned, as long as you are using an open source tool, we are very happy that it is happening. Whether it is Fedora on your desktop, or Ubuntu or SUSE, it is okay as long as you are using a Linux environment. To have a Linux environment flourishing is more important from my perspective. When it comes to declaring a particular distro as the top position holder, it is fine because people have the freedom of choosing the distro they want. There are people who want to stick to one flavour of a particular distribution that they are more comfortable with. Making this choice is perfectly valid and legitimate, I think. There would be other sets of people who switch to different platforms because they want to learn new things and find out ways of doing the same things in other ways or with different distributions. I don't think that is in any way negative. It is actually a very positive thing to happen because it gives people that choice. At the end of the day, whatever you do from a front-end point of view could be different, but at the back-end, it is exactly the same for all the Linux distros, be it Fedora or Ubuntu. The Linux kernel is the same, you are using the same server applications, Firefox, LibreOffice, VLC, etc. So it doesn't matter which distribution you are using as long as you can use the apps that you require.